SPOKES

Skills for Life

Money Management

Part 2: Save Money Before You Spend It -- The Cushion Challenge

Teacher's Guide

Instructor Speaking Notes, Discussion Prompts & Slide Guide

WIPPEA Lesson Format

This guide walks you through every slide in sequence with speaking notes, discussion prompts to spark class conversation, teaching tips, handout references showing when to distribute materials, and a printable checklist of everything you need before class.

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Strategic Planning in Occupational Knowledge for Employment and Success

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Printable Resources Checklist -- See the final page

W CHAPTER 1: WARM-UP -- MEET JESS

WARM-UP

SLIDE 1 -- Meet Jess

Story Intro

Speaking Notes:

Part 2 runs about 10 minutes and is taught as one idea through one story. Before class, open The Cushion Challenge on the classroom screen and press Start over. It opens in Class mode: large text for the projector, lettered choices, and answers that wait until you reveal them. Check that the Class mode button at the top says On.

Play the Meet Jess video at the top of the screen (about one minute, captions on). It introduces Jess, a mom of two who found work through SPOKES, and ends by asking the class to help her.

Then point to the facts on screen: she still gets SNAP, her take-home pay is $400 a week, and every dollar already has a job. Her goal is a small cushion so one bad week does not turn into a crisis.

[VIDEO] Meet Jess (about one minute, captioned)

DISCUSSION PROMPT

Ask: 'What is one surprise cost families run into?' Take two or three quick answers. Ask for the kind of cost, never the amount.

TEACHING TIP

Jess and her numbers are made up on purpose. No one shares their own income, benefits, or balances at any point in Part 2. Say this out loud before you start.

1 CHAPTER 2: INTRODUCTION -- THE IDEA

INTRODUCTION

SLIDE 1 -- State the Goal

Instructor Talk

Speaking Notes:

Give the one idea of Part 2 in a sentence before Month 1:

'Save a little first, automatically, somewhere safe, so a small cushion protects your family. You can do it while on benefits.'

Point to the cushion meter and its gold goal line at $250. Tell the class they will make Jess's choices for four months of paydays and watch what each choice does. Each month stands for four weekly paydays, so a weekly amount counts four times.

TEACHING TIP

How each vote works: read the question, and the class calls out or holds up a letter (A, B, C or D). Click the winning choice, or press that letter on the keyboard. The meter does not move yet, and the class can still change its pick until you reveal it. Ask one or two learners why they picked it, then click Reveal what happens. Keep each vote to about 30 seconds to stay inside 10 minutes.

TEACHING TIP

Going back: every screen after Meet Jess has a Back button. On a screen the class already answered, Change this answer clears that answer and every answer after it, and the meter goes back to where it stood. Use it when the class wants to see what a different choice would have done.

P CHAPTER 3: MONTHS 1 AND 2

PRESENTATION

SLIDE 2 -- Month 1: How Much Does Jess Save First?

Class Vote

Speaking Notes:

Choices: save $10, $25, or $50 first each payday ($40, $100, or $200 a month), or save what's left at the end of each week.

If the class picks 'save what's left,' let it play out: by the end of each week nothing is left. That is the lesson, so no correction is needed.

Pop-up line to say: 'Pay yourself first. Treat savings like a bill you pay the day money arrives. The habit matters more than the amount.'

> **DISCUSSION PROMPT**
>
> Ask: 'Why does saving at the end of the week usually mean saving nothing?'

SLIDE 3 -- Month 2: Where Should Jess Keep Her Savings?

Class Vote

Speaking Notes:

Choices: a jar at home, an account with a $12 monthly fee and overdraft charges, or a Bank On-style account.

Expected answer: the Bank On-style account. The fee account loses $12 every month. The jar looks fine now, but Jess dips $40 out of it in Month 3.

Pop-up line to say: 'Keep savings somewhere safe. Bank On certified accounts have no overdraft fees, need $25 or less to open, and are federally insured.'

> **TEACHING TIP**
>
> If a learner asks where to find a Bank On account locally, say you will follow up. The team is checking which nearby banks or credit unions offer one.

SLIDE 4 -- Month 2: Make Saving Automatic?

Class Vote

Speaking Notes:
Jess's employer can split her direct deposit so the same amount goes to savings every payday.

Expected answer: yes. If the class says no, Jess skips saving during a busy Month 3 -- the class will see the difference on the meter.

Pop-up line to say: 'Set it once. Automatic saving does not depend on remembering or willpower.'

SLIDE 5 -- Month 2: Emergency or Planned?

Class Vote

Speaking Notes:
School picture day costs $30, and the form came home two weeks ago.

Expected answer: planned cost. An emergency is something you did not see coming. School pictures, birthdays, and car registration come every year, so they belong in the weekly plan, not the cushion.

> **DISCUSSION PROMPT**
> Ask: 'What other costs come every year that we could plan for?'

P CHAPTER 4: MONTHS 3 AND 4

PRACTICE

SLIDE 6 -- Month 3: Flat Tire

Story Event

Speaking Notes:
No vote here. The screen applies this month's saving, then a $120 flat tire hits.

If the cushion covered it, point out what that prevented: no late rent, no borrowing, no missed shift. If Jess came up a little short, note that a slightly bigger cushion would have covered it. If she had nothing saved, the screen says she borrowed the whole repair: point out that even a small cushion would have helped.

Pop-up line to say: 'Families with $250 to $749 saved were less likely to be evicted or miss a housing or utility payment after a money shock.' (Urban Institute, April 2016)

SLIDE 7 -- Month 3: The SNAP Question

Class Vote

Speaking Notes:
A friend tells Jess that saving will cost her SNAP. Choices: stop saving, keep it quiet, or ask her caseworker how savings affects her benefits.

Expected answer: ask her caseworker.

Pop-up line to say: 'In West Virginia, SNAP lists no limit on savings for most households. WV WORKS is different: it counts savings, so check with a caseworker.' (USDA FNS, June 2026)

> **TEACHING TIP**
> If a learner asks about their own benefits, thank them and point them to their caseworker. Do not give eligibility advice, and do not quote a WV WORKS dollar limit -- the team has not verified the current figure.

SLIDE 8 -- Month 4: Tax Refund

Class Vote

Speaking Notes:
Jess's $1,200 refund arrives. Choices: $0, $100, $300, or $600 to savings first.

Any amount above $0 is a good answer. The point is deciding before the money is spent.

Pop-up line to say: 'You can split a federal refund into up to three accounts, including savings, when you e-file or with Form 8888.' (IRS)

E CHAPTER 5: EVALUATION -- HOW IT WENT

EVALUATION

SLIDE 9 -- How It Went

Results

Speaking Notes:

The screen shows Jess's final cushion in two parts: what came from her saving habit and what came from her tax refund. It says whether her savings covered the flat tire, then lists what helped and what held her back. If the refund did most of the work, point that out: a flat tire does not wait for refund season. Read the one-sentence idea at the bottom aloud.

Use the class's votes during the game as evidence of understanding. Learners who chose save-first, a safe account, automation, and asking a caseworker have met the objective.

DISCUSSION PROMPT

Ask: 'Which one choice made the biggest difference for Jess?' Listen for: saving first or making it automatic.

TEACHING TIP

Short on time? Skip the discussion and move to Your Turn. Want to show the contrast? Press Play again and make the opposite choices -- it takes about two minutes.

A CHAPTER 6: APPLICATION -- YOUR TURN

APPLICATION

SLIDE 10 -- Your Turn: My First Step

Personal Commitment

Speaking Notes:

Each learner picks one first step for this week:

1. Pick an amount to save first each payday
2. Open a safe place for savings
3. Set up one automatic transfer or split deposit
4. Ask my caseworker one question about saving
5. Plan part of my tax refund before it arrives

In Class mode the screen lists the five steps and tells learners to circle one on their paper card. Nothing personal goes on the big screen. The amount line is optional, and cards are not collected.

A learner with a device can open the game with Class mode off and make a private card on the last screen.

HANDOUT My First Step card -- one per learner. Print Part2_My_First_Step_Cards.pdf (four cards per page) and cut on the dashed lines.

TEACHING TIP

One-on-one: turn Class mode off. The game shrinks to laptop size and each answer shows right away. Virtual groups: keep Class mode on, share your screen, and have learners type a letter in the chat.

Materials Checklist

Print Before Class

	Resource	Location
[ ]	The Cushion Challenge (HTML)	cushion-challenge.html in the Part 2 folder
[ ]	Projector, smart board, or shared screen	Open the game, press Start over, check Class mode is On
[ ]	Speakers for the Meet Jess video	Video and captions play inside the game
[ ]	My First Step cards	Part2_My_First_Step_Cards.pdf, 4 per page, cut apart
[ ]	Part 2 Lesson Plan	Teacher-Resources folder
[ ]	Pens or pencils	For paper cards

Note: All resources are available in the Handouts folder and linked in the presentation sidebar under Resources.